PHIL1002: Introduction to Critical Thinking

Lecture 1B: Recognising Argument–I

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Agenda: Recognising Argument

Part 1

1. **Recognising argument**
2. Factors that can make it difficult to recognise an argument

Part 2

1. Factors that can make it look like there is an argument when there isn't.
2. Modal expressions

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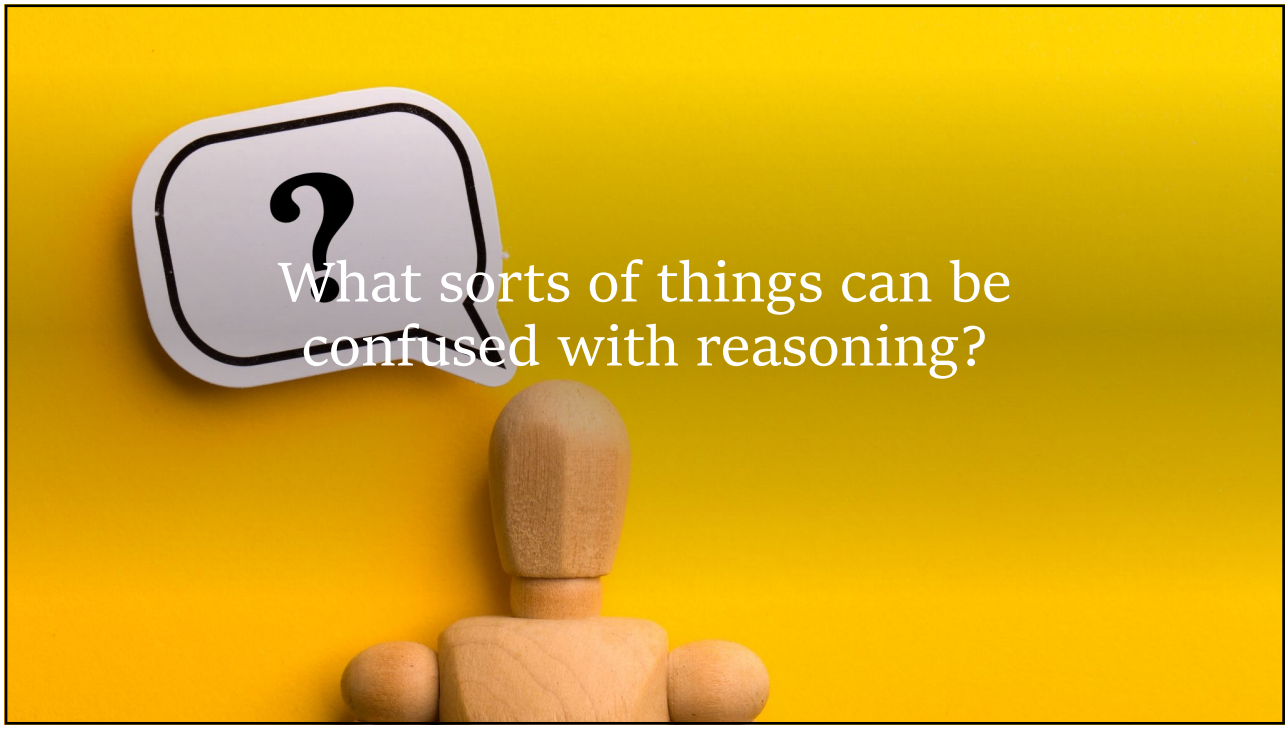
What sorts of things can be confused with reasoning?

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3 ways of getting someone to *believe* or *do* something

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Causes

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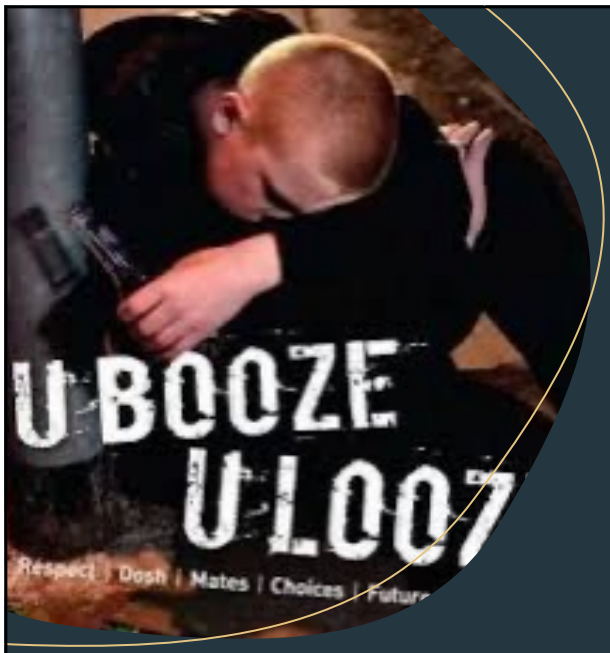

Motives

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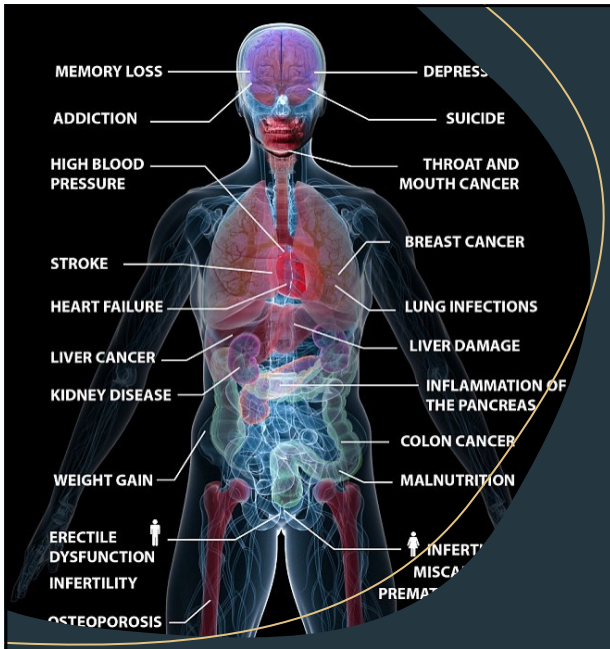

Reasons

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Why are reasons different?

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Reasons set you free (aw...!)

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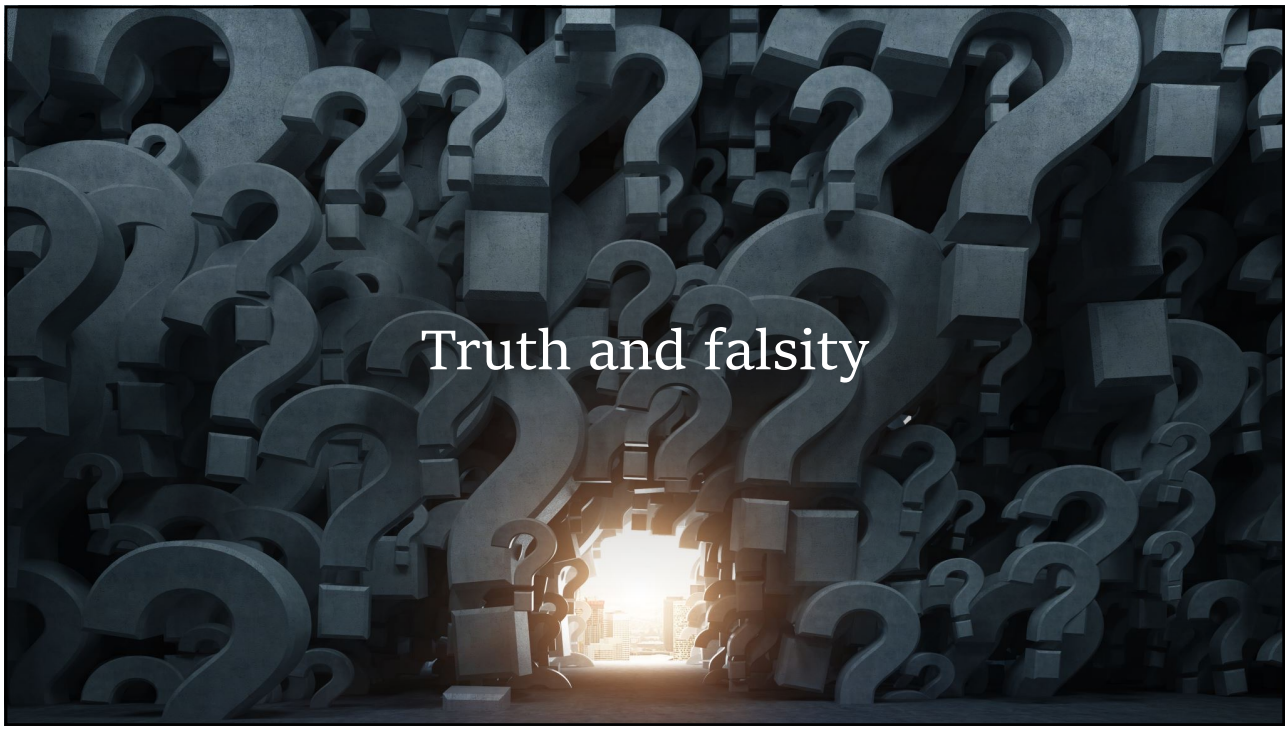

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Reasoning and argument

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Recognising arguments…

Distinguishing arguments from non-arguments is NOT THE SAME as distinguishing good argument from bad ones.

ARGUMENTS & REASONING COME IN MANY FORMS

- Might be in prose, but sometimes in poetry
- Often it is not even spoken or written:

Certain actions can be *expressive* of reasoning

BUT If we want to examine an argument we have to represent it in some way.

We have to use sentences, even though they might not have been used in the original case.

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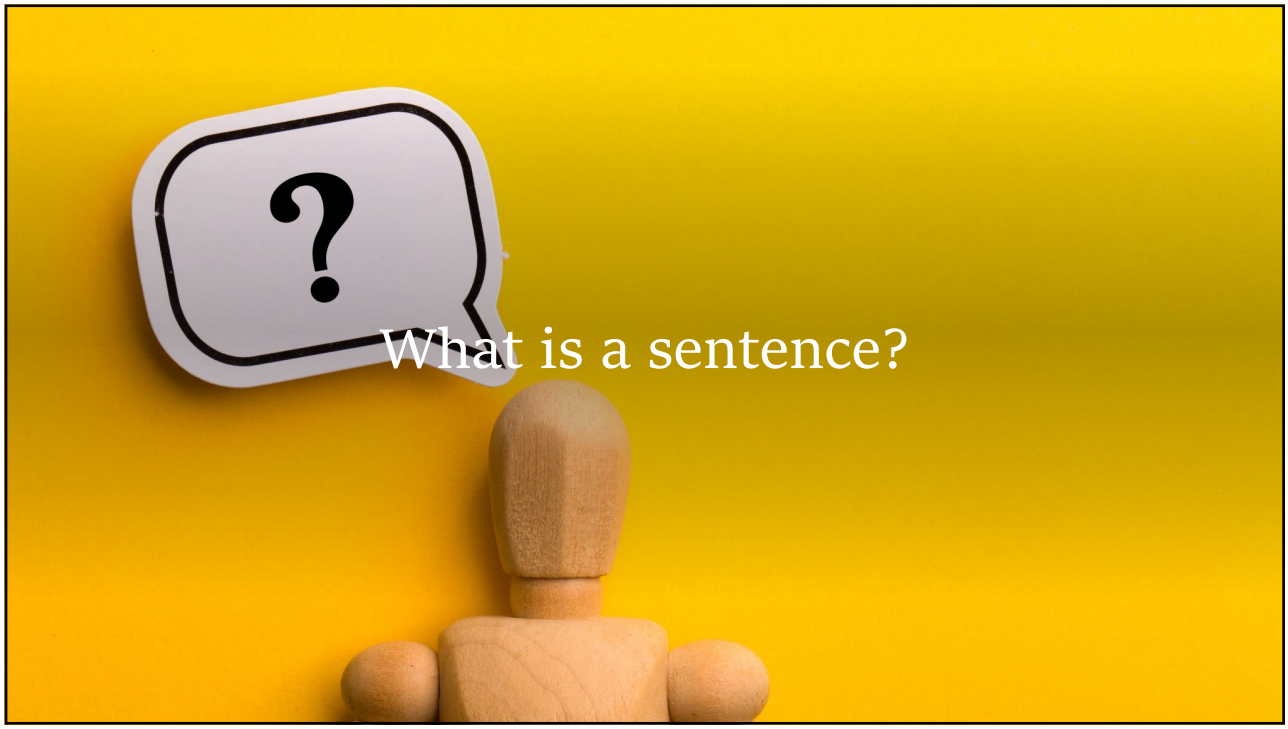

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All these are sentences…

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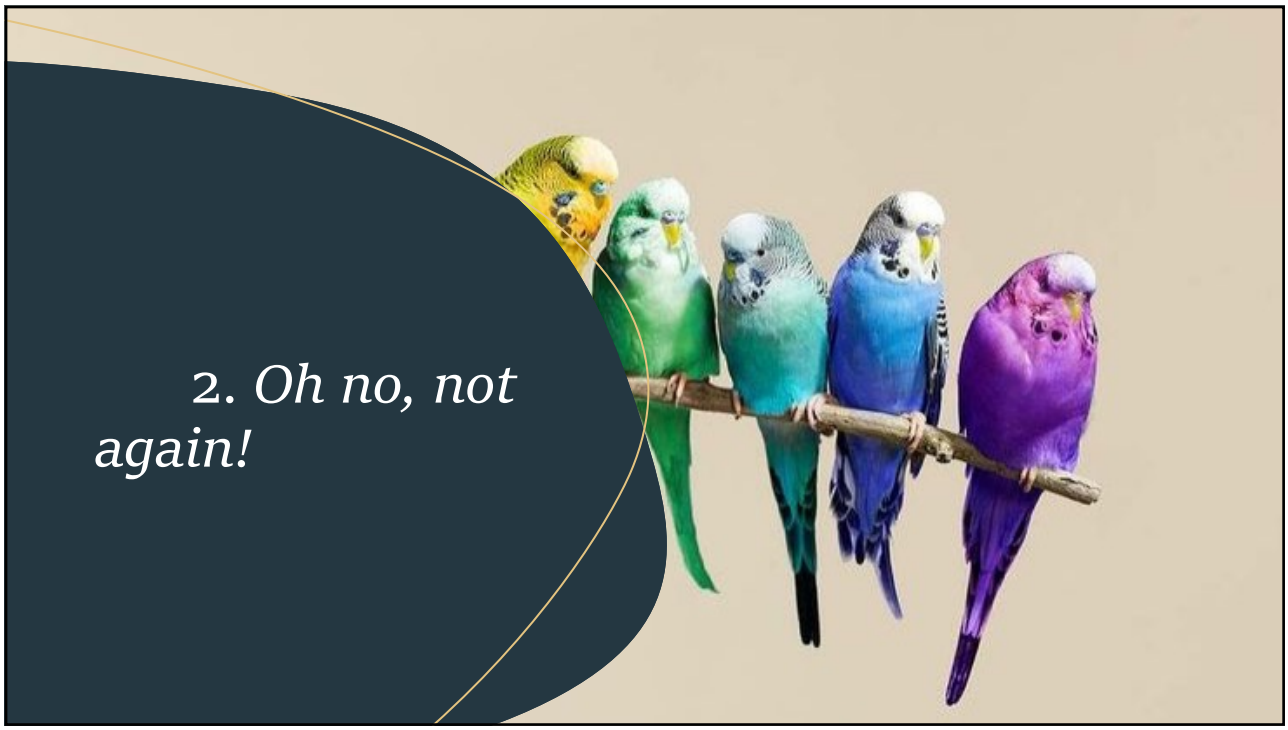

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3. *Yes.*

17

4. *How can we get her to stop devouring the children's pets?*

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5. *A psychoanalyst should be able to uncover her repressed memories of her childhood fantasies; they're responsible for her present dysfunctional behaviour.*

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6. *Give it a rest!*

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Declarative sentences

The main tools of the trade in reasoning BECAUSE

their ***function*** is to assert, to make claims,

to state facts, to DECLARE things to be TRUE or FALSE.

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Compound and simple sentences

Sentence 1: '*Grannie has eaten the budgie.*'

Sentence 5: '*A psychoanalyst should be able to uncover her repressed memories of her childhood fantasies; they're responsible for her present dysfunctional behaviour.*'

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Agenda: Recognising Argument

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1. Recognising argument
2. **Factors that can make it difficult to recognise an argument**

Part 2

1. Factors that can make it look like there is an argument when there isn't.
2. Modal expressions

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1. Grammatical form and function

Factors that make it difficult to recognize an argument

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Grammatical form and function

WE ARE INTERESTED IN **GRAMMATICAL FUNCTION**

- Grammatical form and function do not always correspond
- Form is a guide to function but it is not always reliable
- We want to know how a sentence is actually functioning in its context.

In spoken English, declaratives often function as questions and interrogatives can function as declaratives.

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An argument almost entirely comprised of rhetorical questions…

'And what if I had been accused of robbing a dead man, Gaffer? You COULDN'T do it.

No. Has a dead man any use for money? Is it possible for a dead man to have money? What world does a dead man belong to? T'other world. What world does money belong to? This world. How can money be a corpse's? Can a corpse own it, want it, spend it, claim it, miss it? Don't try to go confounding the rights and wrongs of things in that way.' (Dickens, *Our Mutual Friend*)

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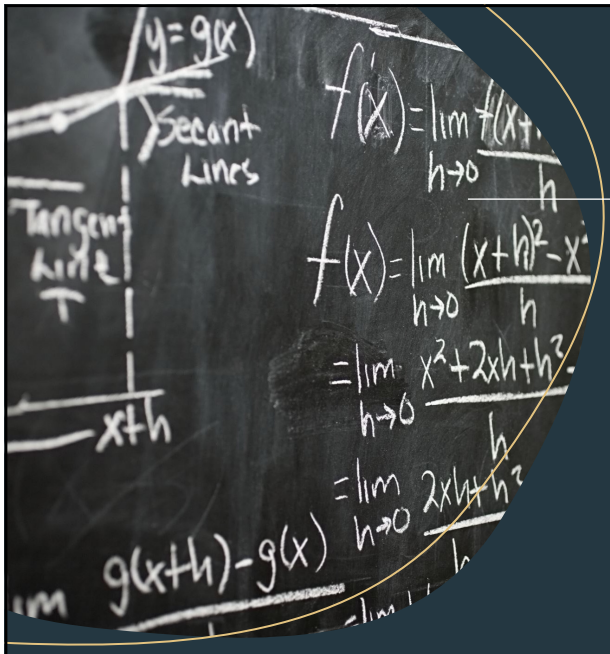

Statements…

- Can be simple or compound
- Function as a declaration
- Have the declarative form
- May be a whole sentence, may just be part of a sentence
- Statements can be *hidden* in sentences…

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Compound statements

Conjunction (and)

where we combine two (or more) statements to make third which says that **each of the simple ones are true.**

Disjunction (or)

where we combine two (or more) statements into a compound statement which says that **either one or other of the simple ones is true**.

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Conjunctions

'and', semi-colon, 'while', 'but', 'although' etc.

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Examples...

1.Grannie devours the children's pets and Grandpa cooks them for her.

2. John has taken up sky-diving; his mother has started going to church.

3. I like reading the horoscopes, but I don't believe a word of it.

4. Michael is a feminist,
while his wife thinks a woman's place is in the home.

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What makes a conjunction true?

If we assert a that a conjunction is true, then we are saying that **each of its conjuncts is also true.**

So, the whole compound statement will be true **only if both of its conjuncts are true**.

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Roles of statements in arguments

An arguments is a discourse in which some statements are offered as justifying, proving or making probable some other statement.

The statement being justified is the **CONCLUSION**

The statements acting to justify the conclusion are the **PREMISES**

The terms **PREMISE** and **CONCLUSION** refer to ROLES which statements play within arguments

The same statement may act, at different times, as conclusion and premise.

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Roles of statements in arguments

The statement 'The cat died'

is a **premise** in:

The cat died, *but the dog didn't, so it must be the cat food which is poisoned.*

but it is a **conclusion** in:

The cat food was poisoned, and there is a putrid smell coming from the cat basket, so I infer that ***the cat died****.*

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Premises and conclusions

One statement may play the role of conclusion and premise in a single piece of reasoning.

The effect here is that we get two (or more) component arguments making up a larger whole.

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An example

It is now three weeks since the python has been fed

(**premise**)

So, the python will eat anything it can find.

(**sub-conclusion** of first sub-argument AND **premise** of second sub-argument)

So, I'm afraid that poor Featherstonehaugh has cashed in his chips.

(**main conclusion**, or conclusion to second sub-argument)

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How do we tell something is an argument?

To determine whether a discourse contains reasoning, ask yourself does the discourse contains statements which are put forward as justifying, proving, disproving, making probable or improbable, other statements within the same discourse.

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Inference

So, argument has to do with the relationships of ***truth and falsity*** among statements,

relationships expressed by the term **inference.**

When the truth or falsity of one statement is ***inferred*** from the truth or falsity of another,

we have ***a piece of reasoning, or an argument***.

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Inference indicators

There are words and phrases whose characteristic function

is to indicate when inference is taking place.

We call them **inference indicators.** (Govier – indicator words!)

There are two kinds of inference indicators:

Premise indicators (because, since, as, for the reason that etc.)

Conclusion indicators (so, therefore, thus etc.)

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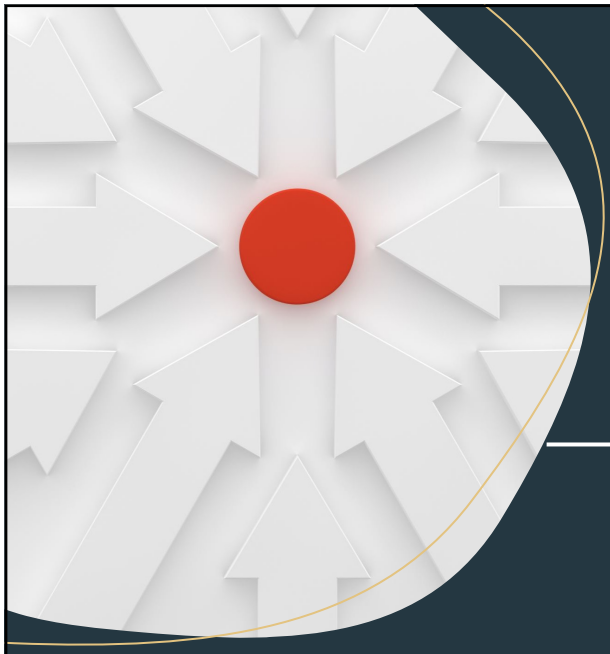

2. Inference indicators can be misleading...

Factors that make it difficult to recognize an argument

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Thus...

The word 'thus' OFTEN serves to introduce the conclusion of an argument

and for this reason, it is a conclusion indicator,

BUT sometimes it merely introduces an illustrative example.

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An example…

We cannot take the least action in this world without killing numerous minute creatures.
Killing per se must ***thus*** *be a morally neutral matter.*

(conclusion indicator)

Mrs Jones was a conscientious mother;
thus, *when she took Nipper for a walk,*
she always made sure that his horns were concealed from view.

(illustrative example)

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As….

'As' often serves to introduce a reason for a conclusion,

that is, it is often a **premise indicator**

BUT

It can sometimes mean something like 'while'.

And sometimes it is hard to tell the difference!

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An example....

As *the present state of the universe cannot be measured exactly* [premise], *future events cannot be predicted exactly* [conclusion].

(premise indicator)

As *he went past the graveyard, he heard a low moan.*

(while)

As *his muscles began to ache under the strain, his attention was distracted.*

(???)

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What about argument without inference indicators?

He won't come tonight. *MAFS* is on TV.

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Context

So, how can we tell if an inferential relationship between statements is intended if there is no explicit indicator?

Use your common sense!

Look at the **context**, for example:

He won't come tonight. MAFS *is on TV.*
You know how much he loves that show.

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Look at the content...

In 1998, a Square Dance convention was held in Perth. Many of the participants arrived by train and spent the journey across the Nullarbor dancing up and down the corridors from morning 'til night. One of the dancers was Russian. He had stainless steel teeth.

NO ARGUMENT HERE!

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Content

"And what if I had been accused of robbing a dead man, Gaffer?
You COULDN'T do it.
Couldn't you, Gaffer?
No. Has a dead man any use for money? Is it possible for a dead man to have money? What world does a dead man belong to? T'other world. What world does money belong to? This world. How can money be a corpse's? Can a corpse own it, want it, spend it, claim it, miss it? Don't try to go confounding the rights and wrongs of things in that way."

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3. Nouns and Noun Phrases

Factors that make it difficult to recognize an argument

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Nouns and noun phrases

Since the king is rather annoyed at losing his toes, it would be wise to avoid disturbing him until his mistress has had time to console him.

(this is OK)

Because of the king's annoyance, we should not disturb him.

(noun phrase 'the king's annoyance' conceals the assertion 'the king is annoyed', but 'because ' is a clear inference indicator)

BOTH EXAMPLES CONTAIN INFERENCE!

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But what about this?

The king's annoyance makes it unwise to disturb him.

This doesn't look like an argument, 'makes it' doesn't look like an inference indicator, BUT this sentence is equivalent to:

The king is annoyed. Therefore, it is unwise to disturb him.

BE WARY OF NOUN PHRASES IN PLACE OF SENTENCES. THEY'RE COMMON IN ENGLISH AND CAN BE MISLEADING.

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4. The implied conclusion

Factors that make it difficult to recognize an argument

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The implied conclusion…

The bigger the burger, the better the burger. The burgers are bigger at Burger King.

Implied conclusion?

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The implied conclusion…

Scientists now believe that in nature, matter cannot be destroyed without being converted to energy. Not even the tiniest particle can disappear without a trace. Nature does not know extinction – only transformation. Would God have less regard for his masterpiece of creation, the human soul? (Wernher von Braun)

Implied conclusion? The human soul is immortal

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Barriers to recognising argument

1. Distinction between the form of a sentence and its function
2. Inference indicators can be misleading
3. Nouns and noun phrases
4. Missing/implied conclusions

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Next lecture…

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